

I intend to do some sort of corpus study in the Luhya language family. A corpus study in linguistics involves a large body of text (spoken or written), called a corpus or corpora. This data can reveal different patterns about a language than other forms of data collection, because the data is not initially collected by a linguist for linguistic-study purposes, naturally revealing patterns that may occur only between speakers or in casual settings. The corpus I will be working with is a collection of stories, or oral literature, told by native Tiriki speakers. This corpus will be the data. The data curation and study design would be the most advanced analytic method as far as I know at this point in time – I still need to meet with my faculty advisor and see what he thinks would be the most valuable study for the community of speakers that we work with.

As an alternate project concept, in case something goes wrong with the first, I am considering designing a dashboard that would help a user visualize ‘linguistic distance’, or how different languages are from each other. I am interested in this because I think it is important to know how some languages are recognized as distinct languages despite being mutually intelligible – meaning, speakers of one can understand the other – and some are considered dialects of the same language despite not being mutually intelligible. It would be interesting to create a dashboard to visualize how many shared/different linguistic features exist across dialects. The data here would be qualitative data regarding a variety of languages belonging to the same language family, and the advanced analytic method would be creating the dashboard.

My faculty advisor is Micheal Dierks!